The truth is, I road-tested a few lines on JLP, but mostly I winged it. I told a few jokes about our childhood, a silly story about Willy's days playing water polo, and then I read a few hilarious snippets culled from letters of support sent in by the general public. One American bloke wrote to say that he'd wanted to make something special for the new Duchess of Cambridge, so he'd set out to capture a ton of ermine, traditional fur of royalty. This overenthusiastic Yank explained that he'd intended to catch *one thousand ermines* for the item of clothing he had in mind (God, was it a tent?) but unfortunately he'd only managed to scare up…two.

Rough year for ermine, I said.

Still, I added, the Yank improvised, made the best of things, as Yanks do, and cobbled together what he had, which I now held aloft.

The room let out a collective gasp.

It was a thong.

Soft, furry, a few silken strings attached to a V-shaped ermine pouch no larger than the ring pouch inside my tunic.

After the collective gasp came a warm, gratifying wave of laughter.

When it died away I closed on a serious note. Mummy: *How she'd have loved to have been here. How she'd have loved Kate, and how she'd have loved seeing this love you've found together.*

As I spoke these words I didn't look up. I didn't want to risk making eye contact with Pa or Camilla—and above all with Willy. I hadn't cried since Mummy's funeral, and I wasn't going to break that streak now.

I also didn't want to see anyone's face but Mummy's. I had the clearest vision in my mind of her beaming on Willy's Big Day, and having a proper laugh about that dead ermine.

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